Diwali, the Festival of Lights, Is Celebrated Today

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Diwali is the most important festival of the year in India, particularly for Hindus, and it is widely marked by prayers, family gatherings, and the lighting of fireworks. More than one billion people across faiths celebrate it in the world's most populous nation and its **diaspora**. This year, Diwali falls on November 8.

The name Diwali comes from "**Deepavali**," meaning "a row of lights." Celebrants place rows of traditional clay oil lamps outside their homes to symbolize the victory of light over darkness and knowledge over ignorance. The festival follows the Hindu **lunar calendar**, typically falling in late October or early November.

While Diwali is a major religious festival for Hindus, it is also observed by Sikhs, Jains, and Buddhists. Its origin stories vary by region but share a theme: the victory of good over evil. In southern India, Diwali celebrates Lord Krishna's victory over the demon Naraka, who is said to have imprisoned women and tormented his subjects. In northern India, it honors the triumphant return of Lord Rama, his wife, Sita, and his brother, Lakshmana, after 14 years of **exile** in the forest.

Traditions vary by region but commonly include lights, fireworks, feasting, new clothes, and prayers. In southern India, many people take an early morning bath with warm oil to symbolize bathing in the holy River Ganges for physical and spiritual **purification**. In the north, worship centers on the goddess Lakshmi, who symbolizes wealth and prosperity. Gambling is a popular tradition, reflecting a belief that those who gamble on Diwali night will prosper throughout the year. Many people buy gold on Dhanteras, the first day of the festival, believing it will bring good luck.

Jains observe Diwali as the day Lord Mahavira, the last of their great teachers, attained nirvana, or liberation from the cycle of birth, death, and rebirth. Sikhs celebrate Bandi Chhor Divas, which overlaps with Diwali, to commemorate the release of Guru Hargobind from imprisonment under the Mughal emperor Jahangir. Some Buddhists mark the day as the anniversary of Emperor Ashoka's conversion to Buddhism in the third century B.C.

Diwali is also celebrated far beyond India. Disney World in Florida held several days of Diwali festivities ahead of the holiday, featuring more than 500 dancers. Diwali at Times Square marked its 11th year in New York City with international performers, cultural bazaars, and a lighting countdown at the Ball Drop Tower. Other community events across North America include Diwali Eve on the Waterfront in Jersey City, a Diwali Family Cruise on the Hudson in New York, Diwali on the Bay in San Francisco, and a Diwali Fusion Bollywood Boat Party in Vancouver, British Columbia.

Word Treasure

diaspora -- People who have moved away from their home country and now live in other parts of the world.

Deepavali -- The older name for Diwali, meaning a row of lights.

lunar calendar -- A calendar that sets dates by the cycles of the moon.

exile -- Being forced to live away from your home for a long time.
purification -- The act of making something clean, in body or in spirit.

Background you need

Diwali is one of the biggest festivals in India, and it is celebrated by Hindus, Sikhs, Jains, and Buddhists, each with its own story behind the day.

Its name means a row of lights, and people place small clay oil lamps outside their homes to stand for light winning over darkness and knowledge winning over ignorance.

The date changes each year because the festival follows the Hindu lunar calendar, which is based on the cycles of the moon.

Families gather to pray, share feasts, wear new clothes, and set off fireworks, and many people also buy gold on the first day of the festival for good luck.

Break it down

LEAD: Diwali, the Festival of Lights, falls today, November 8, and more than one billion people celebrate it in India and around the world.

KEY EVENT: The festival marks the victory of light over darkness and good over evil.

+- MEANING: The name Diwali comes from 'Deepavali,' meaning 'a row of lights,' and people place clay oil lamps outside their homes.

+- SOUTH: In southern India it celebrates Lord Krishna's victory over the demon Naraka.

+- NORTH: In northern India it honors Lord Rama's return with Sita and Lakshmana after 14 years of exile.

+- OTHER FAITHS: Jains mark Lord Mahavira attaining nirvana, Sikhs mark Bandi Chhor Divas, and some Buddhists mark Emperor Ashoka's conversion.

KEY EVENT: Traditions vary by region but include lights, fireworks, feasting, new clothes, and prayers.

+- SOUTH: An early morning bath with warm oil symbolizes bathing in the holy River Ganges.

+- NORTH: Worship centers on the goddess Lakshmi, who symbolizes wealth and prosperity.

+- CUSTOMS: Some people gamble on Diwali night, and many buy gold on Dhanteras, the first day of the festival.

KEY EVENT: Diwali is also celebrated far beyond India.

+- FLORIDA: Disney World held several days of festivities with more than 500 dancers.

+- NEW YORK: Diwali at Times Square marked its 11th year, and other events took place in Jersey City and on the Hudson.

+- ELSEWHERE: Events were also held in San Francisco and Vancouver, British Columbia.

OPEN QUESTION: How do different communities keep their own Diwali traditions alive while celebrating together in new places?

Why it matters

Diwali shows how one festival can carry different stories for different faiths while sharing the same hope that light wins over darkness. For the many families who celebrate it far from India, it is also a way to keep their culture alive in a new home.

Test what you remember

1. When does Diwali fall this year?

- (A) October 31
- (B) December 25
- (C) January 1
- (D) November 8

2. What does "Deepavali" mean?

- (A) A row of lights
- (B) A feast of sweets
- (C) A dance of joy
- (D) A night of fireworks

3. In southern India, whose victory does Diwali celebrate?

- (A) Emperor Ashoka's conversion
- (B) Lord Krishna's victory over the demon Naraka
- (C) Guru Hargobind's release
- (D) Lord Rama's return from exile

4. In northern India, what does Diwali honor?

- (A) Lord Krishna's victory over Naraka
- (B) The release of Guru Hargobind
- (C) Lord Mahavira attaining nirvana
- (D) The return of Lord Rama, Sita, and Lakshmana after 14 years of exile

5. How many dancers took part in the Diwali festivities at Disney World in Florida?

- (A) More than 1,000
- (B) More than 100
- (C) More than 50
- (D) More than 500

6. What do Jains observe on Diwali?

- (A) The release of Guru Hargobind
- (B) The conversion of Emperor Ashoka
- (C) The return of Lord Rama
- (D) The day Lord Mahavira attained nirvana

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: B 4: D 5: D 6: D

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):